material life and religion greatly expanded our understanding of the Indian past. Many Chinese translations of Indian Buddhist texts, the earliest of which date to fifth century CE, were recognized as the closest approximations of the Indian originals. This was similar to the ‘rediscovery’ of the ancient Graeco-Roman antiquity in Europe and of ancient Greek texts we know only through Arabic translations from the ‘golden age’ of Islam in the ninth and tenth centuries.

Many Journeys, One Goal

Faxian was ‘the pioneer of all’, wrote Yijing.[6] A native of Wuyang in today’s Shanxi Province, Faxian’s three older brothers all died before ‘shedding their first teeth’.[7] His father exposed young Faxian to a Buddhist sangha and then sent him to a monastery, where the boy apparently felt quite at home. Both his parents died when he was around ten. By the time he completed his apprenticeship and was ordained a full monk, Faxian was noted for his courage, intelligence and self-control. ‘Deploring the mutilated and imperfect state of the collection of the Books of Discipline’, Faxian decided to visit India to gather texts on the *Vinaya Pitaka*, or monastic rules for monks and nuns.[8] It’s not clear why he had to wait until he was in his early sixties to set out on the land route to India with four fellow pilgrims.

The five pilgrims crossed the Gobi Desert, with its ‘many evil demons and hot winds’. There were no tracks to follow, wrote Faxian. ‘Though you look all round most earnestly to find where you can cross, you know not where to make your choice, the only mark and indication being the dry bones of the dead [upon the sand].’[9] Later, when his party had great difficulties crossing rivers, he described their sufferings as ‘unparalleled in human experience’. Despite the hardships, Faxian and his companions often found Buddhist communities and monasteries across Central Asia, which aided and hosted them en route. They reached the Indian Subcontinent via Khotan, c. 402 CE, and passed Gandhara, Takshashila and the kingdom of Purushapura (modern Peshawar). By the time they reached central India, they had been on the road for six years!